



Kgosientsho Ramokgopa

(koh-see-EN-tshoh rah-moh-KGO-pah)

Minister of Electricity and Energy
Republic of South Africa

Addressed as: **Honorable Minister** | Office held since: **July 2024**

Kgosientsho David Ramokgopa is a confident politician who prides himself on his competency, hands-on approach, and reputation for solving South Africa's hardest problems.

▣ Proving Himself

Ramokgopa favors high-risk, high-visibility tasks because “if your dreams or assignments do not scare you, it’s not worth pursuing”—advice he received from his father. He told relatives “don’t feel sorry for me. When I raised my hand, I knew what was coming.”

▣ Aiming Higher

Ramokgopa, who insists that he has largely ended “load shedding,” a term for debilitating rolling blackouts, is pursuing the next phase of South Africa’s energy journey: energy security as a driver of economic security, industrial competitiveness and national resilience.

Ramokgopa has been increasingly discussed as a possible successor to President Cyril Ramaphosa. Several media outlets last year indicated that he has been exploring a bid, but he has only admitted that he has been approached about a potential bid.

WHY THEY MATTER

Ramokgopa is seeking foreign partners to close the country's approaching gas-supply gap, promoting state ownership and strategic direction alongside a much larger role for private capital.

▣ Welcoming Foreign Capital

Ramokgopa is candid that the scale of South Africa's energy needs exceeds what the state can finance itself. His department is deliberately opening transmission and generation infrastructure to private capital, while retaining state oversight.

▣ Asserting South African Sovereignty

Ramokgopa is insistent that foreign investment must strengthen South African industrial capacity, not merely extract value. He has said that Africa should not be a passive recipient of imported foreign technology and foreign financing while exporting its own resources.

Ramokgopa takes responsibility for failed deals, especially due to poor collaboration. When TotalEnergies withdrew from the Brulpadda/Luiperd offshore gas discoveries after spending \$400 million, he blamed South Africa rather than the company: "Could we have done more? Yes."

MEETING WITH THEM

Ramokgopa is an informal, energetic, and metrics-obsessed interlocutor who disarms counterparts with his introspection and personal touch.

▣ **Low Protocol, High Substance**

Ramokgopa comes off as relaxed and approachable, yet supremely confident in his command of the material. He has acknowledged that “one of my weaknesses is that I get to be a bit more technical... it's one thing to rhapsodise, it's something else to explain how you are resolving a problem at a technical level.”

▣ **Low Ego, High Performance**

While some media initially described him as "cocky," Ramokgopa is more humble than meets the eye. He owns mistakes — noting "in hindsight, we should have communicated the message better" about a cancelled festival. He is proud of his record but frames it as self-evident: "with me you don't have to believe me — it's just whether your lights are on or off."

Ramokgopa's humor and passion are part of his appeal. He jokes about his dancing videos going viral: "every time I dance we go to stage six"—referring to pressure on the electricity grid that necessitates taking 6,000 MW offline.

ON THEIR MIND

▣ **South African Currency Strengthening**

The South African rand strengthened in mid-August to its strongest level since the United States and Israel launched attacks on Iran on February 28, as rising gold prices and a weaker dollar boosted the commodity-linked currency.

▣ **South African Court Blocks Shell Oil Exploration**

South Africa's Constitutional Court in early August set aside exploration rights held by oil giant Shell and Impact Africa, a South African oil and gas company. The ruling prevents the companies from exploring for fossil fuels off South Africa's Wild Coast.

▣ **Eskom Targets Data Centers**

Eskom, South Africa's state-owned utility, is courting major tech companies about providing power to their data centers after ending years of rolling blackouts. Eskom's boss in mid-August said “we are having discussions with the Amazons, the Microsofts, the Googles. We love those discussions because those are power-hungry sectors”

▣ **Upcoming Local Elections**

South Africa's local government elections on November 4, 2026 are shaping up to serve as a key test for the ruling ANC, especially as it has been losing vote share and its grip on urban areas over the past decade.

NETWORK

Ramokgopa's international profile is substantial but relatively recent and highly sector-specific, built through multilateral platforms, investment missions, and diplomacy with Asian, Middle Eastern, and Western counterparts.

He has chaired the Africa Green Hydrogen Alliance, represented South Africa at the 68th IAEA General Conference, and played a prominent role in the G20 Energy Transitions Working Group. He engages global counterparts and investors regularly, holding to South Africa's just-transition framework and seeking to preserve key bilateral relationships, despite Trump-era policies.

Ramokgopa has greatly benefited from President Ramaphosa's backing, especially in turf war with peers, and has maintained or deepened ties to other African National Congress (ANC) powerbrokers and opposition figures.

After failing to secure renomination as mayor of Tshwane, Ramokgopa received a lifeline: Ramaphosa brought him into the presidency, promoted him to minister, and steadily ceded him authority over rivals. He maintains ties to Deputy President Paul Mashatile and his aunt Gwen Ramokgopa, the ANC's Treasurer-General. His former deputy, opposition politician Samantha Graham-Maré, said they developed a "fantastic relationship."

CONTROVERSIES

Ramokgopa, who has been accused of scandals when he was Mayor Tshwane and endured criticism of mismanagement as minister, is comfortable with explaining his position, submitting to legal processes, or dismissing allegations with a quip.

▣ **PEU Smart-Meter Deal**

During Ramokgopa's tenure as Tshwane mayor, the city entered a smart prepaid-meter arrangement with PEU Capital Partners that the Gauteng High Court later ruled constitutionally invalid. The R950 million termination agreement was set aside, imposing large financial liabilities on subsequent governments. No court has found that Ramokgopa personally received an improper benefit.

▣ **Tribe One Dinokeng Festival**

Also as mayor, Tshwane committed approximately R65 million in public funds to the Tribe One Dinokeng music festival, including a R25 million grant to a Sony joint venture. The festival was cancelled. A leaked KPMG forensic report questioned approval processes, value for money, and oversight. No court finding of personal corruption against Ramokgopa has been located.

Ramokgopa is unfazed by questions about scandals. In 2024, he patiently walked through each allegation on a popular podcast show. When asked on a scale of 1 to 10 how corrupt he was as mayor, he answered "zero zero zero." Earlier, in response to heated social media commentary about wearing a Patek Philippe luxury watch, he admitted it was "one of those fake things. You know, I was going to be screened. It's not worth R4m and I've had it for years and there are many others that I buy."

CAREER HIGHLIGHTS

- ▣ **Minister of Electricity and Energy**, Republic of South Africa (2024 - present)
- ▣ **Minister in the Presidency for Electricity**, Republic of South Africa (2023 - 2024)
- ▣ **Head, Investment and Infrastructure Office**, The Presidency (2019 - 2023)
- ▣ **Member of the Executive Council**, Gauteng Province (2019)
- ▣ **Executive Mayor**, City of Tshwane (2010 - 2016)
- ▣ **CEO**, Johannesburg Fresh Produce Market (2006)
- ▣ **Ward Councillor**, City of Tshwane (2000 to 2005)

BIO

Ramokgopa's ascent to the energy ministry is the culmination of a career built on party loyalty, engineering credentials, and township populism that keeps him rooted where he started. Born on January 25, 1975 in Atteridgeville, Ramokgopa talks about “multiple generations of the struggle,” being “born into this political consciousness.” His home was a meeting place for activists, two of his brothers went into exile, and he participated in the South African Students Congress and ANC Youth League.

▣ **Engineering Excellence**

Ramokgopa earned a BSc in Civil Engineering from the University of Durban-Westville in 1998, followed by a Master of Public Administration (University of Pretoria), a Master of Business Leadership (UNISA), and a PhD in Public Affairs (University of Pretoria). At his first Eskom plant tour, he told workers he is a civil engineer, not an electrical or mechanical engineer, and that they understood the equipment better than he did.

▣ **Football Fanatic**

Ramokgopa is passionate about football. He played as a younger man and still goes on the pitch, earning the nickname "Sputla", which is slang for being a nimble, flashy player who could dribble past defenders with dizzying skill. His current team is Mamelodi Sundowns FC—he posts tactical match commentary and has praised the club's "carpet, sumptuous and clinical football"—but he has admitted being a past fan of the Kaizer Chiefs and is still a fan of FC Barcelona.

Ramokgopa is married to Georgia Sekeshe who worked as his personal assistant when he was Tshwane Mayor. They have at least one son. Ramokgopa is an avid reader, and likes to invoke Pablo Neruda, Robert Oppenheimer, and Kwame Nkrumah in his writings. He speaks English and Sepedi, and possibly some Afrikaans and Sesotho.